

Qroo Paul's Intermediate Spanish

Word Order of Adjectives

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Introduction: Hey everybody, Qroo Paul here! In today's lesson, we're diving deep into the fascinating world of **adjectives in Spanish** and their **word order**. You might remember that when you first learned about adjectives in Spanish, you were taught two main things:

1. Adjectives agree in **number and gender** with the noun they modify.
2. Adjectives usually follow the noun.

However, as you become more comfortable with Spanish, you'll start to notice that sometimes, adjectives appear **before the noun**, and that can change the meaning! In this lesson, we explore when and why that happens.

Restrictive vs. Non-restrictive Adjectives:

1. **Restrictive Adjectives:** These are adjectives that describe **objective qualities** of a noun, helping to differentiate it from others. They **always** follow the noun.
 - Example: *Una casa grande* (A big house)
 - Example: *Pan integral* (Wheat bread, literally "integral bread")
2. **Non-restrictive Adjectives:** These adjectives add **extra information** or express a **subjective opinion** about the noun. They can be placed **before** or **after** the noun, but when placed before, they emphasize importance or a personal view.
 - Example: *La hermosa ciudad de San Miguel de Allende* (The beautiful city of San Miguel de Allende)
 - Example: *Una deliciosa torta* (A delicious dessert)

Changing Meaning Based on Position: Some adjectives in Spanish change their meaning depending on whether they are placed before or after the noun. Here are a few examples:

- **Antiguo:**
 - *Un antiguo amigo* (An old friend, from the past)
 - *Una casa antigua* (An ancient house)
- **Pobre:**
 - *El pobre hombre* (The unfortunate man)

- *Un hombre pobre* (A poor man, without money)
- **Nuevo:**
 - *Un nuevo coche* (A new car, new to you, possibly used)
 - *Un coche nuevo* (A brand-new car)
- **Grande:**
 - *Un gran libro* (A great book)
 - *Un libro grande* (A large book)
- **Mismo:**
 - *La misma historia* (The same story)
 - *La historia misma* (The story itself)
- **Simple:**
 - *Un simple adorno* (A mere decoration)
 - *Un adorno simple* (A simple decoration)
- **Único:**
 - *Mi único problema* (My only problem)
 - *Un problema único* (A unique problem)
- **Viejo:**
 - *Un viejo amigo* (An old friend, a longtime friend)
 - *Un amigo viejo* (An old friend, in age)
- **Diferente:**
 - *Diferentes ideas* (Various ideas)
 - *Ideas diferentes* (Different ideas)

Special Cases: Bueno and Malo

- **Bueno:**
 - *Es un buen poeta* (He's a good poet, talented)
 - *Es un poeta bueno* (He's a good poet, morally good)

- **Malo:**
 - *Es un mal doctor* (He's a bad doctor, not skilled)
 - *Es un doctor malo* (He's a bad doctor, unethical)

Adjectives That Always Come Before the Noun: Some adjectives always precede the noun, such as:

- **Mucho** (a lot of)
 - *Mucho trabajo* (A lot of work)
- **Poco** (little, few)
 - *Poco tiempo* (Little time)
- **Ambos** (both)
 - *Ambos padres* (Both parents)

Ordinal Numbers: Ordinal numbers like *primero* (first), *segundo* (second), *tercero* (third), etc., generally come before the noun they modify, but sometimes can follow the noun, especially in titles.

- Example: *El primer capítulo* (The first chapter)
- Example: *Carlos Quinto* (Charles the Fifth)

Conclusion: Understanding the placement of adjectives in Spanish can greatly impact the meaning of your sentences. By keeping these guidelines in mind, you'll gain a deeper appreciation for the nuances of the Spanish language. Thanks for being a member of the Qroo Spanish crew! Until next time, **hasta luego!**